

SHALESH RAWAL

CAUGHT ON THE WRONG FOOT: Sonia Gandhi

But that was before the Election Commission handed the party chief a notice on her birthday on December 9. Then the Congress did yet another U-turn. With the ease of a practiced politician, Singhvi sidestepped the Modi reference and pointed out that "no names appear on the text. The text of the speech is there for all to see". Replying to the Election Commission notice, the Congress stated that "no individual had been named".

The confusion prevails on other issues also. When asked if the nuclear debate had given the 'sense of the House' as the Opposition is claiming, party spokesman and Union Minister of State for Communications and IT Shakeel Ahmad said, "It was a very enlightening debate." Unfortunately, party spokesmen are rarely as enlightening.

by Priya Sahgal



A Flip-flop Show

DELHI It's the gap between information and broadcasting. The recent flip-flop by Congress spokesmen over Sonia Gandhi's comments in Gujarat is a stark example of lack of communication between the Congress president and the rest of the party.

When the controversy

over Sonia's "merchant of death" remark concerning Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi broke, Union Minister for Science and Technology Kapil Sibal said, "Mrs Gandhi said nothing against Modi. She was talking about the manner in which certain state officials were func-

tioning." BJP scoffed at the Congress for backtracking. The next day, party spokesman Abhishek Singhvi contradicted Sibal: "Of course she did (refer to Modi). You can see the statement."

That Singhvi had called a special briefing merely to contradict a statement shows that he had been "authorised" to rebut Sibal, who is also a legal luminary.

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Of the 11 general secretaries in AICC, nine have been allotted secretaries to assist them. But among those still awaiting such assistance are Digvijay Singh and, surprise surprise, the most powerful of them all—Rahul Gandhi.

VOICES

"It is not Narendra Modi but UPA which is a merchant of death as it has failed to take effective measures to check terrorists even in the Capital."

L. K. Advani, leader of the Opposition

"I am quitting BJP because I feel my party is committing suicide for an individual (Narendra Modi). I don't want to be part of such an undemocratic outfit."

Suresh Mehta, former Gujarat chief minister

"I shouldn't have criticised the Congress. I am prepared to climb atop the Himalayas and shout that it was a mistake. If the Congress weakens, India weakens."

K. Karunakaran, former Congress leader

"Why should people always eat rice? If there is rice shortage, let them have two eggs and a glass of milk to satisfy their hunger. It is more nutritious than rice anyway."

C. Divakaran, food and civil supplies minister, Kerala

"Forget about whose nose might have been put out of joint, the Australians still fear Virender Sehwag from the last tour. Now was not the right time to give up on him."

Ian Chappell, former Australian cricket captain